

Curriculum Vita

Laron K. Williams

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Current Position

Professor (2021-present), Truman School of Government and Public Affairs, University of Missouri.

Frederick A. Middlebush Chair (2020-present), Truman School of Government and Public Affairs, University of Missouri.

Previous Position

Director of Graduate Studies and Placement Director (August 2018-2023), Truman School of Government and Public Affairs, University of Missouri.

Associate Professor (2015-2021), Department of Political Science, University of Missouri.

Assistant Professor (2011-2015), Department of Political Science, University of Missouri.

Assistant Professor (August 2009-July 2011), Department of Political Science, Texas Tech University.

Education

Ph.D., Political Science, Texas A&M University. December 2008. Concentrations: Comparative Politics (Nations of Concentration: Advanced Industrial Democracies), International Relations (Conflict Studies), and Quantitative Methods. Dissertation: *Challenging Government: Institutional Arrangements, Policy Shocks and No-Confidence Motions*, advisors Guy D. Whitten (chair), Alex Pacek, Michael Koch, Robert Walker, Hank Jenkins-Smith and Jeffrey Engel.

B.S., *summa cum laude*, Political Science, University of Nebraska at Kearney, May 2003.

Empirical Implications of Theoretical Models Summer Institute, University of Michigan. June-July 2009.

Recent Awards

Professor of the Year (Arts & Science), University of Missouri, 2023

Gold Chalk Award for Excellence in Teaching (Graduate Professional Council), University of Missouri, 2023

Outstanding Director of Graduate Studies Award (Graduate School), University of Missouri, 2023

Research

Peer-Reviewed Publications

Books

1. David Fortunato, Thiago N. Silva and Laron K. Williams, *Voters' Perceptions of Party Brands* Cambridge University Press Elements (2025).

Articles

43. Sebastian Juhl and Laron K. Williams. "Expanding the Spatial Toolkit with Spatial Eigenfunction Modeling." *The Journal of Politics* forthcoming
42. David Fortunato, Sebastian Juhl and Laron K. Williams, "The Economic Roots of Cross-National Similarity in Voter Preferences." *American Journal of Political Science* 2025: 1203-1217.
41. Victor Shin* and Laron K. Williams, "The Space Between: How Ideological Similarity Limits the Effectiveness of Ambiguity." *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion and Politics* 2024: 202-224.
40. Steven Jokinsky*, Christine S. Lipsmeyer, Andrew Q. Philips, Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "Look Over There. Where? A Compositional Approach to Modeling Public Opinion on the Most Important Problem." *Social Science Quarterly* 2024: 913-933.
39. T. Murat Yildirim and Laron K. Williams, "Problem Importance across Time and Space: Updating the 'Most Important Problem Dataset'", *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion and Politics* 2024: 1-16.
38. Sebastian Juhl* and Laron K. Williams, "Learning at Home and Abroad: How Competition Conditions the Diffusion of Party Strategies." *British Journal of Political Science* 2022: 593-612
37. Cameron Wimpy, Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "X Marks the Spot: Unlocking the Treasure of Spatial-X Models." *Journal of Politics* 2021: 722-739
36. Guy D. Whitten, Laron K. Williams and Cameron Wimpy, "Interpretation: The Final Spatial Frontier." *Political Science Research and Methods* 2021: 140-156
35. Cody A. Drolc*, Christopher Gandrud, and Laron K. Williams, "Taking Time (and Space) Seriously: How Scholars Falsely Infer Policy Diffusion from Model Misspecification." *Policy Studies Journal* 2021: 484-515
34. Edward Goldring*, Brandon Beomseob Park* and Laron K. Williams, "Should We Talk about the Weather? How Party Competition and Coalition Participation Influence Parties' Attention to Economic Issues", *Party Politics* 2020: 730-743
33. Colton Heffington*, Brandon Beomseob Park* and Laron K. Williams, "The 'Most Important Problem' Dataset (MIPD): A New Dataset on American Issue Importance", *Conflict Management and Peace Science* 2019: 312-335
32. Laron K. Williams, "Guns Yield Butter? Exploring the Individual-Level Variation in Defense Spending Attitudes", *The Journal of Conflict Resolution* 2019: 1193-1221

31. Laron K. Williams, "Temporal Dependence and the Sensitivity of Quantities of Interest: A Solution for a Common Problem", *International Studies Quarterly* 2018: 892-902
30. Raymond M. Duch, Kent L. Tedin and Laron K. Williams, "North American Public Opinion on Health and Smoking", *Public Opinion Quarterly* 2018: 171-199
29. David Fortunato, Clint S. Swift* and Laron K. Williams, "All Economics Is Local: Spatial Aggregations of Economic Information", *Political Science Research & Methods* 2018: 467-487.
28. Christopher Gandrud and Laron K. Williams, "Simulating Probabilistic Long-Term Effects in Models with Temporal Dependence", *The R Journal* 2017: 401-408
27. Inaki Sagarzazu and Laron K. Williams, "Making and Breaking Party Leaders: An Informational Theory of Temporary and Lasting Impacts of Prime Minister Debates in Spain", *Social Science Quarterly* 2017: 856-875
26. Laron K. Williams, Mary Stegmaier, and Marc Debus, "Relaxing the Constant Economic Vote Restriction: Economic Evaluations and Party Support in Germany", *Party Politics* 2017: 286-296
25. Laron K. Williams, "Opposition Parties and the Timing of Successful No-Confidence Motions", *Political Science Research & Methods* September 2016: 533-553
24. Christopher Gandrud, Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "Visualize Dynamic Simulations of Autoregressive Relationships in R", *The Political Methodologist* Spring 2016: 6-10
23. Laron K. Williams, "Long-Term Effects for Models with Temporal Dependence", *Political Analysis* Spring 2016
22. Mary Stegmaier and Laron K. Williams, "Forecasting the 2015 British Election through Party Popularity Functions", *Electoral Studies* 2016: 260-263
21. Laron K. Williams, "Estimating the Defense Spending Vote", *Electoral Studies* 2015: 243-255
20. Laron K. Williams, Katsunori Seki* and Guy D. Whitten, "You've Got Some Explaining To Do: The Influence of Economic Conditions and Spatial Competition on Party Strategy", *Political Science Research & Methods* 2016: 47-63
19. Laron K. Williams, "It's All Relative: Spatial Positioning of Parties and Ideological Shifts", *European Journal of Political Research* 2015: 141-159
18. Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "Don't Stand So Close to Me: Spatial Contagion Effects and Party Competition", *American Journal of Political Science* April 2015: 309-325
17. Zeynep Somer-Topcu and Laron K. Williams, "Opposition Party Policy Shifts in Response to No-Confidence Motions", *European Journal of Political Research* August 2014: 600-616
16. Katsunori Seki* and Laron K. Williams, "Updating the Party Government Dataset", *Electoral Studies* June 2014: 270-279
15. Laron K. Williams, "Hawks, Doves and Opportunistic Opposition Parties," *Journal of Peace Research* 2014: 111-125
14. Laron K. Williams and David J. Brule, "Predictably Unpredictable: The Effects of Conflict Involvement on the Error Variance of Vote Models," *British Journal of Political Science* April 2014: 777-798
13. Laron K. Williams, Michael T. Koch and Jason M. Smith, "The Political Consequences of Terrorism: Terror Events, Casualties, and Government Duration," *International Studies Perspectives* 2013: 343-361

12. Harvey D. Palmer, Guy D. Whitten and Laron K. Williams, "Who Should Be the Chef? The Dynamics of Valence Evaluations across Income Groups During Economic Crises," *Electoral Studies* 2013: 425-431
11. Laron K. Williams, "Flexible Election Timing and International Conflict," *International Studies Quarterly* 2013: 449-461
10. John D. Gerlach, Laron K. Williams and Colleen E. Forcina, "The Science-Natural Resource Policy Relationship: How Aspects of Diffusion Theory Explain Data Selection for Making Biodiversity Management Decisions," *Politics & Policy* 2013: 326-354
9. John D. Gerlach, Laron K. Williams and Colleen E. Forcina, "Data Selection for Making Biodiversity Management Decisions: Best Available Science and Institutionalized Agency Norms," *Administration & Society* 2012: 213-241
8. Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "But Wait There's More! Maximizing Substantive Inferences in TSCS Models," *Journal of Politics* July 2012: 685-693
7. Laron K. Williams, "Pick Your Poison: Economic Crises, International Monetary Fund Structural Adjustment and Leader Survival," *International Political Science Review* March 2012: 131-149
6. Laron K. Williams, "Unsuccessful Success? Failed No-Confidence Motions, Competence Signals, and Electoral Support," *Comparative Political Studies* November 2011: 1474-1499
5. Laron K. Williams and Guy D. Whitten, "Dynamic Simulations of Autoregressive Relationships," *the Stata Journal* 2011: 1-12
4. Guy D. Whitten and Laron K. Williams, "Buttery Guns and Welfare Hawks: the Politics of Defense Spending in Advanced Democracies," *the American Journal of Political Science* January 2011: 117-134
3. Laron K. Williams, David J. Brule and Michael T. Koch, "War Voting: Interstate Disputes, the Economy, and Electoral Outcomes," *Conflict Management and Peace Science* November 2010: 442-460
2. David J. Brule and Laron K. Williams, "Democracy and Diversion: Aggressive Foreign Responses to Domestic Economic Problems," *Journal of Peace Research* November 2009: 777-798
1. Zeynep Somer-Topcu and Laron K. Williams, "Survival of the Fittest? Cabinet Duration in Post-Communist Europe," *Comparative Politics* April 2008: 313- 329

* Graduate student at the time of writing

Editor-Reviewed Publications

- Bryce Reeder, Stephen Quackenbush and Laron K. Williams, Introduction to Virtual Online Issue, "International Conflict Data Collection: Where Have We Been and Where Are We Going?" *Conflict Management and Peace Science*, Published online September 2017.

Current Research

- Laron K. Williams, "Interpretation with a Purpose: A Guide to Theory-Driven Interpretation of Empirical Models", under contract with Cambridge University Press
- T. Murat Yildirim, Min Kyu Chang* and Laron K. Williams, "Issue Prioritization across Time and Space: Exploring Responses to the Most Important Problem Question"
- David Fortunato, Thiago N. Silva, Rylie Wieseler* and Laron K. Williams, "Missingness and Inferential Errors in the Study of Voters' Perceptions of Parties' Positions"

- Sebastian Juhl and Laron K. Williams, “When Space Is Just a Nuisance: A Simple Solution for Spatial Dependence”
- Laron K. Williams and Cameron Wimpy, “Lost in Space? Tools to Make Spatial Analysis Reproducible”

Software

- `dynsim`: Dynamic Simulations of Autoregressive Relationships. Available in Stata (with Guy D. Whitten) and R (with Christopher Gandrud and Guy D. Whitten).
 - Nominated for the Society for Political Methodology Statistical Software Award (2016).
- `pltesim`: An R Package for Simulating Probabilistic Long-Term Effects in Models with Temporal Dependence (with Christopher Gandrud).

Datasets

- Update to the *Party Government* Data Set, 1945-2014 (with Katsunori Seki).
- The ‘Most Important Problem’ Dataset (MIPD) (with Colton Heffington and Brandon Beomseob Park).

Selected Conference Presentations

- “Who Cares about Foreign Policy? An Analysis of Issue Importance in the US, 1939-2012”, (with Colton Heffington), Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association.
- “A Hybrid Model of Spatial Evaluations”, (with Clinton Swift and David Fortunato), Methodological Innovations in Comparative Politics, Texas A&M University, 2015.
- “Elite Messages, Economic Conditions and Retrospective Evaluations”, University of Sao Paulo, 2015.
- “Compression and the Variability of Substantive Effects”, paper presented at the Robustness Testing and the Empirical Analysis of Observational Data, Cologne Center for Comparative Politics, Germany, 2014.
- “Guns Yield Butter? Exploring the Individual-Level Variation in Defense Spending Attitudes,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the European Political Science Association, Edinburgh, Scotland, 2014.
- “The Dynamics of German Party Support,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the European Political Science Association, Edinburgh, Scotland, 2014.
- “Estimating the Conditional War Vote,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the European Political Science Association, Barcelona, Spain, 2013.
- “It’s All Relative: Spatial Positioning of Parties and Ideological Shifts,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, Chicago, IL, 2012.
- “Hawks, Doves, and Opportunistic Opposition Parties,” paper presented at the European Union Center at Texas A&M University, College Station, TX, 2010.
- “Flexible Election Timing and International Conflict,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Midwest Political Science Association, Chicago, IL, 2010.
- “But Wait There’s More! Maximizing Substantive Inferences in TSCS Models,” paper presented at the St. Louis Area Methods Meeting, St. Louis, MO, 2010 (with Guy D. Whitten).

- “The (Domestic) Political Consequences of Interstate Disputes among Advanced Democracies,” paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the International Studies Association, San Francisco, CA, 2008 (with David J. Brule)

Teaching Experience

Course Instructor

- *Introduction to Political Analysis*: Fall 2007, Spring 2008, Fall 2008 and Spring 2009 (Texas A&M University), Fall 2010 (Texas Tech University), Spring 2014, Fall 2014, Spring 2019, Fall 2019, Fall 2020, Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Spring 2022 and Spring 2024 (University of Missouri)
- *Introduction to American Government*: Spring 2009 (Texas A&M University), Fall 2009, Summer 2010 and Fall 2010 (Texas Tech University), Summer 2013 (University of Missouri)
- *Introduction to International Relations*: Spring 2009, Spring 2010, Spring 2011 and Summer 2011 (Texas Tech University)
- *Introduction to Comparative Politics*: Summer 2008 (Texas A&M University), Fall 2011, Summer 2012, Fall 2013 and Fall 2018 (University of Missouri)
- *Introduction to Formal Models*: Spring 2012 (University of Missouri)
- *Comparative Political Behavior*: Spring 2012 and Spring 2013 (University of Missouri)
- *Research Design & Analysis (Graduate)*: Summer 2019, Summer 2022 and Summer 2023 (University of Missouri)
- *Readings in Political Science (Graduate)*: Summer 2019, Summer 2022 and Summer 2023 (University of Missouri)
- *Introductory Statistics for Political Scientists (Graduate)*: Fall 2015 (University of Missouri)
- *Introduction to Comparative Politics (Graduate)*: Fall 2011, Fall 2013 and Fall 2023 (University of Missouri)
- *Comparative Political Behavior (Graduate)*: Spring 2013 and Spring 2020 (University of Missouri)
- *Comparative Political Institutions (Graduate)*: Spring 2014 and Fall 2021 (University of Missouri)
- *Time Series Analysis (Graduate)*: Fall 2019 (University of Missouri)
- *Maximum Likelihood Estimation (Graduate)*: Fall 2014, Fall 2018, Fall 2020 and Fall 2023 (University of Missouri)
- *International Conflict (Graduate)*: Fall 2009 (Texas Tech University)
- *Domestic Politics & International Conflict (Graduate)*: Spring 2011 (Texas Tech University)

Additional Graduate Instruction in Methodology

- *Workshop for New Graduate Students in Quantitative Methods*: Summer 2006, Summer 2007 and Summer 2008 (Texas A&M University), Fall 2014, Spring 2015, Fall 2015, Spring 2016, Fall 2016, Spring 2017, Fall 2017, Spring 2018, Fall 2018 and Summer 2019 (University of Missouri)
- *Short Course on Maximum Likelihood Estimation*: February 2013 (University of Texas at Dallas)
- *Workshops in Methodology*: University of Missouri

- “Introduction to Programming in Stata”
 - “Introduction to Simulation Methods”
 - “Guidelines for Interactions”
 - “Dealing with Dynamics”
 - “Introduction to L^AT_EX”
 - “Writing for Political Science”
 - “Mathematics for Political Science”
 - “Effective Presentation of Quantitative Information”
 - “Introduction to Spatial Econometrics”
 - “Navigating the Publication Minefield”
- Co-Instructor, *Modern Regression Analysis*: June 2016, July 2017, and July 2019 (FLACSO, Mexico City)
 - Instructor, *Quantitative Analysis for the Social Sciences*: June 2023 (FLACSO, Mexico City; Virtual)
 - Instructor, *Basics of Spatial Interdependence in Theory and Practice*: January-February 2017, January 2018, and January 2019 (University of Sao Paulo)
 - Instructor, *Comparative Survey Analysis*: January 2020 (University of Sao Paulo)

Research and Teaching Interests

Comparative Politics

Comparative political behavior; party competition.

Political Methodology

Empirical implications of theoretical models; techniques to improve interpretation of substantive effects; time series; spatial econometrics.

Service

Department

Chair, Korea Foundation Endowed Professor Search Committee, 2023

Chair, Promotion Committee, 2023

Chair, Comparative Public Policy Search Committee, 2021

Chair, Ph.D. Committee, 2018-2023

Chair, Lectures Committee, 2014-2015

Chair, Awards Committee, 2013-2014

Co-Chair, Brownbag Series, 2013-2015

Member, Executive Committee, 2014-2018

Member, Curriculum Committee, 2018-2023

Member, International Relations Search Committee, 2017

Member, Kinder Institute Professor of Constitutional Democracy Search Committee, 2016

Member, Comparative Politics Search Committee, 2013

Member, Graduate Studies Committee, 2013-2018

Organizer, Workshops in Methodology, 2013-2023

University

Member, University of Missouri, Missouri Unions Committee, 2015-2018

Member, University of Missouri, College of Arts and Sciences, Faculty Responsibility Committee, 2015-present

Faculty Advisor, University of Missouri, Graduate Association in Political Science (GAPS), 2013-2018

Faculty Advisor, University of Missouri, Sigma Tau Gamma fraternity, 2011-2014

Discipline

Reviewer, National Science Foundation, Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grants, 2017-2019

Editorial Board, *Political Research Quarterly*, 2016-2018

Editorial Board, *Political Science Research and Methods*, 2015-2023

Co-Media Editor, *Political Science Research and Methods*, 2015-2019

Referee, National Science Foundation, *American Political Science Review*, *American Journal of Political Science*, *Journal of Politics*, *British Journal of Political Science*, *Political Analysis*, *International Studies Quarterly*, *Comparative Politics*, *Journal of Theoretical Politics*, *Electoral Studies*, among others

References

References available upon request